Bitter Creek Junction

By Linda Hasselstrom

As usual, the shortcut proves
longer than the map promised.
I cross the railroad tracks
and nothing looks familiar anymore
I dry my forehead on my sleeve.
Clench my jaw, teeth grinding grit.

How long has it been? Not long enough.
Two men in a beat-up white sedan
once followed me on the interstate.
They passed a dozen times, edging closer.
When I drove fast, hoping to flush out
a cop with radar, they kept pace,
easing ever closer. For miles I looked
for a ranch house, gas station, any place
I might find help or haven. Side by side
we raced along the highway, doing eighty.
The fender of the white car
grazed mine as they passed again.

I'd had enough. The driver dropped back
beside me once more, smirking while
the other man whooped, "Pull over, honey!"
I laid the barrel of my pistol
flat across my steering arm,
and watched his tires. One inch closer

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and I'd pull the trigger. No need to aim.
The white car shot away. Years later
I still grip the steering wheel,
remembering, my knuckles white.

INTRODUCTION

All cruelty springs from weakness. The philosopher Seneca made this observation more than 2,000 years ago and still it rings true today. As women we are physically weaker than our male counterparts and for an incomprehensibly large portion of our society, this weakness spontaneously combusts into cruelty in the form of domestic violence. In a country where the amount spent to shelter animals is three times the amount spent to provide emergency shelter to women from domestic abuse situations, it is little wonder that women are forced unthinkable survival strategies. Want to know more? Travel with me to ***Linda Hasselstrom's Bitter Creek Junction.***

Rattling on a pole, a crumpled sign

announces, "Gas Bar" beside a fuel pump's

broken concrete base. I stand

in waist-high weeds to fill the tank.

Three beat-up pickups nose against the wall,

boxes full of chain and oily rags.

A skinny cat slumps at a corner.

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I step through the open door and pause,
dazed by the dark inside, the smell
of beer gone flat, spoiled food.
The place is half groceries, half saloon.

"Git out of her way!"
A gaunt man shoulders me aside
to slap a toddling girl.
He grabs her arm, and shakes her
while her dark eyes reach for mine.
"Pay attention when I talk to you!"
He yanks her hair to make her face him.
"How much?" he says. Shoves the girl away.
"I'm talkin' to you, Blondie. How much gas?
I don't have no way to know that
from in here."

"Nine fifty-five," I say, and notice
the woman in the gloom behind the bar.
She sets beer before three men,
who turn their head to look at me.

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Her long dark hair hangs straight,
not hiding bruises on her eyes and cheeks.
She takes the bill I give her,
hands me coins in change and never
once looks up. The child clings to her skirt.

At the bar, one man elbows another,
spins around to leer at me,
his legs spread wide. He grins
and scratches slowly. "Saturday night!"
one says. "Time to party!"
The jowly one points his bottle at me,
yelps, "Party enough for all of us right there."
I yank my cap low, getting ready
for the ceaseless prairie crosswinds.
I plant my feet apart and take the time
to squint and glare at every man.

Cans and bottles rattle in the back room.
The man yells, "Yer brat's been drinkin pop again,
squaw. I'll tan her hide!" The three men laugh.

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The child stands at my knee, looking up.
I dig for the ten in my pocket as I kneel.
"You're a good girl," I say, and slip
the folded bill into her muddy little hand.
Smoothly, she makes the money vanish
without a glance behind her.

I grip my car keys like a weapon
in my right hand, open the car door
with my left. I turn the ignition
while I shift, and the men inside stand up.
I spin the steering wheel and gun it,
clang gravel off the signs and pickup windows.
One tough woman howls a challenge
from my stereo. Roaring up the access road,
I drop between two trucks,
lock the needle at eighty-five.
I keep up with the convoy
while I watch for headlights
to follow me from Bitter Creek.

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Bonnie Raitt joins me running west.
She rides shotgun, crooning songs
of freedom, blues about the men
who have abused and left us all,
and what we hope will happen to them.
While my car burns the costly fuel
from Bitter Creek, I sing so loud
I know I'm trying not to think,
don't want to guess how many times
she's been called a *squaw.*
I want to pray for that woman,
for the child, even for the man.
Sisters! Pray for the souls of the damned,
but teach your daughters to be brave.

As I drive a shaft of light
across that black and stony plain
I brood about the woman and her daughter.
I know some deer hunter
may one day stumble on their bones
scattered in an icy gulch.

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I grind my teeth and dream revenge,
test the polished edge of rage against my fear.
I chase the sunset's light,
carve a path through shadows,
leaving tracks I hope that she will follow.

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A woman must be smart
to survive, must understand
when her time has come.
She can't take more abuse
than her daughter can stand.
Already the child's eyes are dim.

While she plans defection,
a cunning woman will pretend servility,
endure the snickers,
endure the men who prod and pinch

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with eyes and fingers.
When he slaps her while they watch
she won't grab the scattergun under the bar.
She'll scurry. Bend. Think.
Not yet. Not yet.
Still, in a land of drunken homesteads,
dead-end roads and desert dust,
a woman often learns
she'll have to help herself.

She might spread old blankets
over the couch, cast them wide and thick.
When he staggers toward their bed,
she could tell him it's her time of month,
wave him toward the other room.
Steady and sober, she'll tuck
the child in early, close the door.
Then wait. Wait until he snores.

She might ease from the covers,
slide her feet over the floor

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to keep the loose board quiet.
Put on a pair of his gloves.
Take the big moss agate from the shelf.
Tie a towel around it.
Make knots to fit her hands.
Swing the weight to test
its mass against her arm.
Standing by the couch, she'll breathe
deeply of his sweat and smoke.
Steady herself. Swing.
Strike between the eyes.
More than once. Then stop.
Push his stench out of her lungs and
listen for his breath. She won't
take time to sob or stare.
She'll drop the rock beside his head.
Wrap the blankets tight.
Without a light, she'll drag him to the pickup.
Drop the tailgate, haul him up.
Cover him with his own tarp,
still bloody from the last poached deer.

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Be sure he has the shovel he used
to bury the guts.
Gloves on, headlights off,
she'll pick a dirt road
pounded every day by a hundred pickups
headed for an oil field or a trona mine.
She knows the roads.

She'll drive deep into the desert,
come home before the day dawns red,
nothing but a shovel rattling
in the truck's bed. Park his truck
the way a drunk would leave it,
sleep sound beside her child.
At daylight she'll inspect the couch,
the ground around the door,
the pickup box. If she sees blood,
she won't wash it out– he wouldn't.
Maybe she'll do as he did every fall,
shoot a dozen of the starving cats,
throw them in the pickup box

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to swell and stink until she hauls
the weekly trash out to the rubbish pile.
If anyone asks about the man,
she'll stay in her familiar shadow.
Shrug. Say little. She didn't notice.
She closed the bar, went to bed
as usual. He was drinking
with some woman, some drillers,
roughnecks she never saw before.
Didn't come to bed. That's all she knows.
She won't mention the bruises
on her face, on the child's arm.
They've all been here to drink
when he was slapping her around.
She'll run the bar the way she always did,
add the money to her hideout cash.
Stay out of trouble. Maybe move
next summer. Find some place
where she can walk in sunshine
with her daughter,
humming an old blues tune.

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—written for the battered woman
at the place I call Bitter Creek for her protection.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Linda Hasselstrom
Book: Land Circle
ISBN: 978-1555910822
Publisher: Fulcrum Publishing
Date(Month/Year): Nov 1991

AWARD HISTORY

S. Dakota State Finalist
2008 National Qualifier

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